



shoulders, we have been privileged to get this historic opportunity to lay the foundation for a vibrant democracy and now we have to live up to the expectations of our people."

For the tiny nation, still untouched by globalisation, foreign investment is regulated and there is no western MNC present in the country, and people are not complaining. Roughly the size of Kerala, the country measures its wealth in terms of the happiness of its people, as gross national happiness as opposed to the gross national product. The going has been good so far. The per capita income at \$1,200 (Rs 48,000) is on an upward spiral and with an impressive growth rate of 9 per cent fuelled by its hydropower-driven economy, the transition comes at an important time.

Thinley's party DPT, which campaigned with the slogan "in pursuit of gross national happiness" and promised protection of the environment, culture, socio-economic development and good governance, won 44 of the 47 seats, while the other party PDP, led by the king's uncle, was completely rejected. It managed to win only three seats. Analysts say the vote was for continuity and DPT won because it had several experienced ministers contesting the elections compared to the

QUIET TRANSITION: Voters outside a poll station in Thimphu, (below) prime minister-elect Thinley

Khesar Namgyel Wangchuck, the 28-year-old Oxford-educated king, criss-crossed the country persuading the people to come out in large numbers and vote. And in a country where the king is considered god, people did, with a high turnout of 79.4 per cent out of the 3,18,465 registered voters.

While political pundits and infant psephologists were predicting a close election, the results came as a surprise to most. The Druk Phuensum Tshogpa (DPT) party swept the elections with a landslide victory over its rival, the People's Democratic Party (PDP). The winning party has promised to work under the guidance of the king and professes closer ties with India. Says Jigme Y. Thinley, former premier and president of DPT, who is expected to be the new prime minister, "It is a huge responsibility on our

relatively young PDP.

Seated in his Tashichoo Dzong office, overlooking the National Assembly where the new Parliament will meet, the King of Bhutan has an air of quiet satisfaction. His Majesty, who still finds time to play basketball with school students in Thimphu, feels that with a democratic government in place he would have more time to spend with his people. "It is a time of deep personal satisfaction. As a son, I am grateful for the opportunity to serve my father through the successful implementation of the democratic transition of Bhutan. As the king, I am extremely proud of our people. For having built a strong and unique nation, we now embark on the journey to build a vibrant Bhutanese democracy," Wangchuck told INDIA TODAY.

The king will now invite the leader of the majority party to form the government. The government will have a term of five years and the prime minister will be allowed to serve a maximum of two terms in office. The king will remain the commander-in-chief of the Bhutan Army. The country will move to a system of constitutional monarchy, and the new government is likely to take office in May. The Parliament will also pass the new Constitution that says that a retirement age of 65 has been fixed for the king. He can also be removed by a joint session of Parliament with a two-third majority. "It is a defining moment, we are rewriting the history of Bhutan, we have moved from the king's rule to people's rule," says Dasho Kunzang Wangdi, chief election commissioner, as he basks under the sun, in his makeshift Election Commission office in the centre of Thimphu.

For the last six months, Wangdi and his team have been working hard to make the country's first election a seamless exercise. They were conducted with active help from India. While the electronic voting machines were visible symbols of support, senior Indian officials were invited as observers. "We have to thank the Indian election commission and the electronic voting machines which really made the big difference. It made our elections smooth and also solved our logistics problems," says Wangdi.

And for a first election, the process



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